

# Revising Your Main Claim

Test and strengthen the thesis you already have — so the argument that drives your essay is as clear and sharp as it can be.

NAME \_\_\_\_\_

DATE \_\_\_\_\_

## 1. Your Current Claim

Write your current thesis or main claim below — exactly as it stands in your draft. Don't clean it up yet.

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## 2. Test Your Claim

A strong main claim is specific, contestable, and significant. Check each box once you're satisfied, and use the notes to think through how you might strengthen it.

### ☐ *Is it specific?*

Is the claim based in evidence? Does it unpack key terms? Does it explain the relationship between ideas? Does it answer questions of "how" and "why?"

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### ☐ *Is it contestable?*

Is the claim something a knowledgeable reader could reasonably doubt? Or is it merely an observation about something factual or obvious?

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☐ *Is it significant?*

Does the claim answer "so what?" Why does this argument matter? How does it help a reader understand something new or nonobvious about the topic?

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### 3. Watch Out for Common Pitfalls

Sometimes claims *look* strong but fall into familiar traps. Check any that apply to your current draft.

☐ *Five-Paragraph Essay Claim*

Makes interpretive moves but doesn't offer something nonobvious. Its structure suggests one paragraph per example, each proving the same point. *Try:* choosing a more specific angle, complicating the claim, or defining key terms more precisely.

☐ *Overstated Claim*

General and absolute — may create a false debate between two options and pick one, ignoring complicating evidence. Watch for "obviously," "only," or "has to." *Try:* adding specificity and accounting for reader doubt.

☐ *Understated Claim*

Contains interesting observations, but the connection between them isn't stated — a reader has to guess. *Try:* spelling out the how/why relationship between your ideas explicitly.

☐ *Descriptive Claim*

Describes what happens but doesn't make an argument a reader would doubt. *Try:* asking "so what?" and "yes, and?" about what you've described.

### 4. Revise Your Claim

Based on everything above, write a revised version. It may look very different from where you started — that's a good sign.

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